The transition towards the swampy plains began in the time of King Ajatashatru (493–462 BCE). He is credited with converting the settlement of Pataligrama into the fortified urban complex which came to be called Pataliputra. As noted, he did this so that it could serve as a base against the aggressive Vajji (or Lichchavi) republic. In later years the Gangetic plains were dominated—as were many other parts of India—by the Magadha-based Mauryas, but at this point in time there were several states in North India, the balance of power fluctuating and shifting between them, creating tensions in their relationships with each other. The Lichchavi confederacy was one of these many states. Militarily, it formed a powerful force defeated by Ajatashatru only after a protracted conflict that lasted sixteen years or more (*c*. 484-468 BCE). The creation of fortifications at Pataligrama was probably an important part of the strategy to protect Magadha's Gangetic flank against the aggressive Lichchavis. Some fifty years later, in the reign of Ajatashatru's successor Udayin, Pataliputra became Magadha's capital city.

So, within some decades of his death, Pataliputra, it would appear, had moved fast towards fulfilling the Buddha's prophecy. Of course, considering that the travels of the great sage and the truisms transmitted by him began to be recorded only after his death—by which time a walled city at Pataliputra already dominated the brow of the Ganga plains—it is also possible that the recording of his prophecy was a retrospective insertion into folklore (of the kind that we encountered around Ashoka in the last chapter).